

PARTICIPANT INFORMATION SHEET

The Influence of Payoff Information on the Choice of Learning Strategies

ETHICAL APPROVAL HAS BEEN GRANTED FOR THIS STUDY TO BE CARRIED OUT BETWEEN
01/10/2025 AND 30/04/2026

You are being invited to take part in a research study. Before you decide, it is important for you to understand why the research is being conducted and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Feel free to ask us if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information. Take your time to decide whether you wish to participate. Thank you for reading this.

What is the purpose of the study?

The purpose of the study is to examine how different learning strategies are chosen in the context of a problem-solving task. Understanding this can help provide insights into improving educational strategies. This study will take approximately 5 minutes to complete, and you will be paid for your participation at the posted rate of £1.00 (at a rate of £12.00 per hour). This research is being undertaken as part of a BSc Psychology degree.

Why have I been invited to participate?

You have been invited to participate because you are a registered user of Prolific Academic, a UK resident and over the age of 18. 180 participants will take part in this research.

Do I have to take part?

Participation in this study is entirely voluntary. It is up to you to decide whether to take part. If you choose to participate, you will be given a chance to save this information sheet and will be asked to provide consent. Your response data will be kept confidential, not shared with any third parties, and used solely for research purposes. It will also be stored securely in a password protected device and kept anonymous. Your individual privacy will be maintained in all published and written data resulting from the study, and your identity will be kept confidential.

During the study, you are requested to carefully read the instructions and complete the task to the best of your ability. You are free to withdraw at any time before the end of the study, without giving a reason, and without penalty. Once the experiment has finished, withdrawal is not possible as the data is collected anonymously.

What will happen to me if I take part?

If you choose to participate, you will take part in an online study that consists of 25 trials. For each trial, you will see a sequence of 0s and 1s. This represents your current solution, with different sequences corresponding to higher or lower scores. You can change or stick with the solution, depending on your choice of learning strategy. Specifically, we are interested in three types of learning strategies: innovating (where you devise your own solution), copying (where you get the solutions to a problem from other participants), and maintaining (where

you stick with the solution you already have). Your goal is to find the best solution, i.e., the sequence of 0s and 1s with the highest score. Once you have selected an option, you will be given feedback about the number of points you received on that trial, as well as your total number of points.

Are there any lifestyle restrictions?

There are no specific lifestyle restrictions associated with participating in this study. You can continue with your normal activities and responsibilities.

What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part?

This is a low-risk study, and we do not anticipate any specific disadvantages or risks associated with your participation. However, should any issues arise, you are free to exit the study at any time by closing the browser. Any recorded data that is incomplete will be deleted upon inspection by the researcher.

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

You will be reimbursed £1.00 via Prolific to thank you for your time. While there may be no direct benefits to you, your participation will contribute to the advancement of psychological research. By participating in this study, you will contribute to our understanding of how individuals use learning strategies to solve problems.

What if something goes wrong?

If you have any concerns or questions about the study, please feel free to contact the researcher or their supervisor (contact email at the end of this form):

- Researcher Name: Neha Ghosalkar
- Supervisor Name: Dr James Winters

If you wish to make a complaint about how the research is being conducted, please contact the Chair of the Ethics Committee:

- Professor Louise Mansfield (contact email at the end of this form).

Will my taking part in this study be kept confidential?

Yes, your participation will be kept strictly confidential. We are not collecting any identifying information during this research from Pythonanywhere or Prolific. All data collected will be anonymised and stored securely in a password protected device. Pythonanywhere will be used to host the website that collects data from the experiment, but no identifying information will be stored. The data will be stored on GDPR compliant servers located in Frankfurt. Once the data arrives on the pythonanywhere server, it is immediately transferred to a Brunel driver using 256-bit encryption (AES-256) and deleted from the pythonanywhere server. Only the researchers involved in the study will have access to the raw data, and any publications or reports resulting from the study will not contain personally identifiable information.

In general, data from taught student studies is typically deleted upon award of the degree, with consent sought at the beginning of the study for retaining the anonymised study data for a minimum of 10 years in the event of publication. With your permission, anonymised data will be stored securely for at least 10 years on a secure server compliant with the Data Protection Act 2018 and the UK General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). The data may be used in future research, but you can indicate whether you give permission for this on the consent form.

Will I be recorded, and how will the recording be used?

No audio or video recordings will be made as part of this study.

What will happen to the results of the research study?

The results of this study may be published in student dissertations and academic journals or presented at conferences. All data will be reported in aggregate form, and individual participants will not be identifiable.

Who is organising and funding the research?

The research is not funded and is being organised by Dr James Winters, Lecturer in Psychology, in conjunction with Brunel University of London.

What are the indemnity arrangements?

Brunel University provides appropriate insurance cover for research that has received ethical approval.

Who has reviewed the study?

The procedures and methods used in low-risk Psychology research studies, such as the current project, have been reviewed by and approved by the College of Health, Medicine and Life Sciences Research Ethics Committee at Brunel University of London.

Research Integrity

Brunel University London is committed to compliance with the Universities UK [Research Integrity Concordat](#). You can expect the highest level of integrity from the researchers during this study.

Contact for Further Information and Complaints

- Researcher Name: Neha Ghosalkar (2376585@brunel.ac.uk)
- Supervisor Name: Dr James Winters (James.Winters@brunel.ac.uk)
- Chair of the College of Health, Medicine, and Life Sciences Ethics Committee, Professor Louise Mansfield (louise.mansfield@brunel.ac.uk).

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